

THE HILL

Episode 1 — “Mulberry Township”

Pilot Script Draft — Act Five

Version 0.1 Continued

ACT FIVE — “TOMORROW”

INT. HORNER HOUSE — PRE-DAWN

Dark.

The fire is low.

Almost gone.

The house is full of sleeping bodies that are not truly resting.

Christopher sleeps curled tight.

John Samuel lies awake.

Mary Ann has dozed sitting up, sewing still in her lap.

William sits near the door, rifle across his knees.

Spencer is awake at the table.

Permelia stands at the hearth, looking at nothing.

No one speaks.

The house listens.

Outside:

Creek water.

Wind.

Nothing else.

That is worse.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — PRE-DAWN

Empty road.

Dark timber.

A low branch moves in the wind.

For a moment it looks like a man.

It is only a branch.

Then, farther back in the trees, a horse exhales.

Not seen.

Only heard.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — PRE-DAWN

John Samuel hears it.

His eyes shift toward William.

William heard it too.

Neither moves.

Spencer's hand tightens on the cup in front of him.

Permelia's face does not change.

Mary Ann opens her eyes.

Nobody asks what that was.

They already know the kind of answer they are afraid of.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — DAWN

Gray light.

No sunrise beauty.

Just enough light to make the yard visible.

The house stands exposed.

The ridge road above it is empty now.

The absence feels arranged.

A chicken moves across the yard.

Scratching.

Ordinary.

Wrong.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — DAWN

Permelia begins the morning because morning has arrived whether anyone wants it or not.

She stirs ash.

Adds wood.

Moves with practiced discipline.

Mary Ann wakes fully.

MARY ANN

You sleep?

Permelia does not answer.

Mary Ann understands.

William stands, stiff from sitting too long.

Spencer watches him.

SPENCER

You can't guard a door forever.

WILLIAM

Don't need forever.

SPENCER

No?

WILLIAM

Just today.

Spencer looks away.

That answer lands harder because William did not mean it as poetry.

EXT. HORNER YARD — MORNING

John Samuel steps outside with a bucket.

He stops at the doorway.

The yard looks the same.

That is the cruelty.

Christopher appears behind him.

CHRISTOPHER

We getting water?

JOHN SAMUEL

I am.

CHRISTOPHER

I can help.

John Samuel looks toward the creek.

Then toward the ridge.

JOHN SAMUEL

Stay by the house.

CHRISTOPHER

You ain't Pa.

John Samuel flinches.

Christopher knows he said something wrong.

He does not know why.

John Samuel takes the bucket and walks alone.

Mary Ann watches from the doorway.

She lets him go because water is still needed.

That is the whole world now:

fear and chores.

EXT. LITTLE MULBERRY CREEK — MORNING

John Samuel fills the bucket.

His hands are small against the handle.

The creek sounds too loud.

He looks upstream.

Nothing.

Downstream.

Nothing.

Then he looks up toward the ridge.

A shape between trees.

Maybe a rider.

Maybe shadow.

He freezes.

The bucket overflows.

Water spills over his hand.

The shape is gone.

Or was never there.

John Samuel grabs the bucket and hurries back.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — MORNING

John Samuel returns too fast.

William sees him.

WILLIAM

What?

John Samuel shakes his head.

Not because there was nothing.

Because he cannot prove there was something.

William reads that.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)

Inside.

John Samuel goes.

William looks toward the creek.

Then the ridge.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — MORNING

Breakfast is not breakfast.

It is food placed on a table.

Spencer stands rather than sits.

Permelia notices.

PERMELIA

Sit or don't. Hovering don't help.

Spencer sits.

Mary Ann gives Christopher food.

Christopher eats.

John Samuel does not.

William leans in the doorway, looking out.

SPENCER

You plan to eat standing?

WILLIAM

I plan to see.

Spencer almost snaps.

Doesn't.

He is too tired.

PERMELIA

Both of you stop making the room smaller.

That lands.

The men go quiet.

EXT. ROAD ABOVE HOMESTEAD — MORNING

Jess Wilson walks his mule along the ridge road.

The borrowed auger is visible now, tied to the pack.

He does not take the road down to the Horner place.

He stops where he can see the house.

He unties the auger.

Looks at it.

Then ties it back.

A decision made and unmade.

A second rider appears behind him.

Then a third, farther back.

This is not the attack.

Not yet.

Jess looks down at the house.

The riders wait.

SECOND RIDER

Today?

Jess watches smoke from the chimney.

The children in the yard.

William at the door.

Spencer near the table through the open doorway.

JESS

Not while he's watching.

SECOND RIDER

He's always watching.

Jess looks at William.

Then at the children.

JESS

Then we wait until he moves.

The riders back into the timber.

The auger goes with them.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATE MORNING

Mary Ann prepares more food than the morning needs.

Chicken again.

Bread.

Work as control.

Permelia watches her.

PERMELIA
That for supper?

MARY ANN
Maybe.

PERMELIA
Maybe ain't a meal.

Mary Ann keeps working.

MARY ANN
If I stop, I hear too much.

Permelia does not correct her.

She understands.

Christopher sits with a small scrap of wood, drawing lines in the dirt floor.

John Samuel watches the door.

Spencer watches John Samuel.

SPENCER
Come here.

John Samuel hesitates, then comes.

Spencer reaches for him and gently turns his face toward him.

SPENCER (CONT'D)
You don't have to carry grown fear.

John Samuel looks at him.

JOHN SAMUEL
Who else will?

Spencer's hand drops.

There is no answer that does not lie.

EXT. FIELD EDGE — MIDDAY

William walks the edge of the field.

The potato patch visible beyond.

The wooded hillside past it.

Safety appears close.

Too close.

He studies the distance from house to timber.

Counts it with his eyes.

A man could almost make it.

Almost.

Lewis appears at the far tree line.

William sees him.

Lewis gives the smallest signal:

stay back.

William stops.

Lewis looks toward the ridge road.

Then back at William.

His face says:

not good.

William turns toward the house.

EXT. HORNER YARD — CONTINUOUS

William returns fast enough that Mary Ann sees the difference.

MARY ANN
What?

WILLIAM
Get the boys inside.

Mary Ann does not ask why.

She calls without raising her voice.

MARY ANN
John Samuel. Christopher. In.

Christopher groans.

CHRISTOPHER
I ain't done.

JOHN SAMUEL
Come on.

John Samuel takes him.

No argument this time.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — MIDDAY

The family gathers inside.

Not dramatically.

Practically.

Spencer looks at William.

SPENCER
What did Lewis see?

WILLIAM
Enough.

SPENCER

That word's getting wore out.

WILLIAM

So is daylight.

Spencer stands.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)

Don't.

SPENCER

I'm going to see my own yard.

WILLIAM

That's what they want.

Spencer stops.

A beat.

SPENCER

Who's they?

William does not answer.

Because any name is both too much and not enough.

Permelia looks at both men.

PERMELIA

Names don't matter if the guns come first.

Silence.

That is the line that holds the room.

EXT. MODERN WORKSPACE — DAY

Daniel at the table.

He has written several phrases:

KNOWN TO HIS FAMILY

INFORMATION MOVES BEFORE VIOLENCE

MAPS LIE

NO CLEAN INVESTIGATION
NEIGHBOR KNOWLEDGE

He adds:

THE LAST ORDINARY DAY

He stares at it.

DANIEL (V.O.)
The record tells us what happened after.

A pencil rests over the map.

DANIEL (V.O.)
It does not tell us the last hour they still thought the day might pass.

He turns to a blank space in his notes.

DANIEL (V.O.)
That is where history becomes quiet enough to hurt.

Cut back.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — AFTERNOON

The day stretches.

Nobody comes.

That becomes its own kind of torment.

Mary Ann works.

Permelia works.

Spencer cleans the rifle again.

William watches.

John Samuel watches William.

Christopher sleeps in the corner, worn out by fear he cannot name.

A fly moves across the table.

Spencer swats it.

The sound is too sharp.

Everyone flinches.

Spencer sees it.

He is ashamed.

SPENCER

Sorry.

That small word hurts more than anger would.

EXT. ROAD ABOVE HOMESTEAD — AFTERNOON

The ridge road is empty.

Then Jess steps into frame on foot.

No horse.

No mule.

He crouches and looks at the tracks.

He touches the dirt where several horses passed.

He looks down toward the house.

The auger is in his hand.

He could walk down now.

Return it.

Make the world normal again.

He does not.

He turns and walks back into the trees.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATE AFTERNOON

Mary Ann lays out the chicken dinner.

This is the meal Act Four began preparing.

Now it returns with heavier weight.

Bread.

Chicken.

Beans.

Molasses.

A meal trying to be ordinary.

Everyone sits.

This time even William sits, though he keeps the rifle within reach.

Spencer notices.

Says nothing.

Christopher eats first.

He is hungry.

That almost breaks Mary Ann.

John Samuel looks at the door.

WILLIAM

Eat.

JOHN SAMUEL

You keep saying that.

WILLIAM

Because you keep not eating.

John Samuel takes a bite.

Spencer looks around the table.

His family.

What remains of it.

SPENCER

Tomorrow I'll go down and speak to Jess.

No one responds.

PERMELIA

No.

Spencer looks at her.

She does not look away.

PERMELIA (CONT'D)

You won't.

SPENCER

Permelia —

PERMELIA

You won't.

William watches his father.

Mary Ann watches the boys.

John Samuel watches everyone.

Spencer lowers his eyes.

For the first time, he lets someone else's fear change his plan.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — SAME

Jess and the riders are farther back now.

Hidden.

The second rider watches the light in the house.

SECOND RIDER

They're eating.

Jess does not answer.

SECOND RIDER (CONT'D)

All of them?

Jess watches.

A long beat.

JESS

Near enough.

SECOND RIDER

Then why wait?

Jess looks toward the field.

Toward the wooded hillside.

Toward the house.

JESS

Because daylight gives a man places to run.

The second rider understands.

The plan is not only to come.

It is to come when the land helps them.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — EVENING

The meal ends.

No one says grace.

No one says thank you.

Mary Ann clears plates.

Permelia gathers scraps.

Spencer sits with his hands on the table.

William stands.

John Samuel rises too.

WILLIAM
Where you going?

JOHN SAMUEL
Door.

WILLIAM
No.

John Samuel stops.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
Window's enough.

John Samuel goes to the window.

Looks out.

The yard is still.

The ridge darkening.

He watches.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — EVENING

The house glows.

The yard is empty.

The field beyond it waits.

The wooded hillside waits.

The ridge road waits.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

Later.

The family settles for sleep without believing in sleep.

Mary Ann tucks Christopher in.

He holds the scrap of wood from earlier.

CHRISTOPHER

Tomorrow can I go to the creek?

Mary Ann freezes.

Then:

MARY ANN

We'll see.

CHRISTOPHER

That means no.

Mary Ann forces a tiny smile.

MARY ANN

It means we'll see.

John Samuel lies beside him.

Christopher rolls over.

JOHN SAMUEL

Don't ask tomorrow.

Christopher whispers:

CHRISTOPHER

Why?

John Samuel does not answer.

Because he does not know how to say:

Tomorrow is not safe.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATER NIGHT

Spencer at the table.

William near the door.

Permelia in the chair by the hearth.

Mary Ann awake on a pallet.

The house in suspended breath.

Outside, the faintest sound:

A horse.

Then another.

This time no one mistakes it for wind.

William's hand moves toward the rifle.

Spencer stands slowly.

Permelia looks toward the children.

Mary Ann covers Christopher's mouth gently before he can wake and speak.

John Samuel's eyes are open.

He is not surprised.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — NIGHT

Dark shapes.

Several now.

Not enough to see faces.

Enough to know they are there.

Jess Wilson sits among them.

The borrowed auger hangs from his saddle.

He looks down toward the house.

The second rider whispers:

SECOND RIDER

Now?

Jess watches the house.

The tiny light.

The people inside.

The field.

The slope.

The road.

JESS

No.

A beat.

JESS (CONT'D)

Morning.

The riders begin to move off, slow and quiet.

Not leaving.

Repositioning.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

The horse sounds fade.

No one relaxes.

William stays at the door.

Spencer stands beside the table.

Permelia closes her eyes for one second.

Mary Ann's hand remains over Christopher's mouth even after he settles.

John Samuel looks toward the doorway.

He whispers, barely audible:

JOHN SAMUEL

Morning.

William hears him.

So does Spencer.

No one corrects him.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — PRE-DAWN

The last image of the pilot:

The Horner house in darkness.

The ridge above it.

The road hidden by timber.

The field pale with the first hint of morning.

The land is waiting.

Cut to black.

END OF PILOT.